

Northwind Analytics: Employee Handbook

Effective 1 January 2026 — Version 3.2

This handbook outlines the workplace policies, benefits, and operational procedures applicable to all Northwind Analytics employees. It supersedes all previous handbook versions and should be read in conjunction with each employee's signed employment contract. Where any conflict arises between this handbook and an individual contract, the contract takes precedence.

1. Working Hours and Remote Work

1.1 Standard Working Hours

The standard working week at Northwind is 37.5 hours, distributed across Monday to Friday. Core hours are 10:00 to 16:00 GMT, during which all employees are expected to be available for meetings and collaboration. Outside of core hours, employees may structure their day according to personal preference, provided their weekly hour commitment is met and project deadlines are honoured.

1.2 Remote Work Policy

Northwind operates a hybrid working model. Employees are required to attend the London office on a minimum of two days per week, with Tuesdays designated as a company-wide in-office day to facilitate cross-team collaboration. Remote work from outside the United Kingdom is permitted for up to 30 calendar days per year, subject to written approval from the employee's line manager and confirmation that the destination meets the company's security and tax compliance requirements.

1.3 Equipment Provision

All employees receive a company-issued laptop, an external monitor, a keyboard, and a mouse upon joining. A one-time home office allowance of £350 is provided to cover the cost of an ergonomic chair or desk. Employees may submit receipts to the Operations team within 60 days of their start date for reimbursement. Replacement equipment is issued every three years or sooner in the event of hardware failure.

2. Leave and Absence

2.1 Annual Leave

Full-time employees are entitled to 28 days of annual leave per calendar year, inclusive of the eight UK public holidays. Annual leave accrues monthly and unused leave may be carried into the following year up to a maximum of five days. Carried leave must be used within the first quarter or it is forfeited. Requests for more than five consecutive working days require approval at least 21 days in advance.

2.2 Sick Leave

Employees are entitled to up to 10 paid sick days per year without requiring medical certification. Absences exceeding three consecutive working days require a fit note from a registered medical

practitioner. Long-term sickness, defined as continuous absence of more than four weeks, is managed under the company's Occupational Health process and may include a referral to an external occupational health provider.

2.3 Parental Leave

Northwind offers enhanced parental leave provisions. Primary caregivers are entitled to 26 weeks at full pay followed by 13 weeks at statutory rate. Secondary caregivers receive 6 weeks at full pay. Eligibility requires a minimum of 12 months of continuous service at the expected date of leave commencement.

3. Compensation and Expenses

3.1 Salary Review

Salaries are reviewed annually each April. The review takes into account individual performance ratings from the previous calendar year, market benchmark data sourced from Radford and Mercer, and the company's overall financial performance. Promotions may also occur outside the annual review window where exceptional circumstances justify it, subject to approval by the relevant department head and the Chief People Officer.

3.2 Expense Reimbursement

Business expenses are reimbursed through the Concur expense system. Receipts must be submitted within 30 days of the expense being incurred. Expenses over £100 require pre-approval from the employee's line manager. Travel expenses are reimbursed at actual cost for public transport and at 45 pence per mile for personal vehicle use, in line with HMRC's approved mileage rates. Hotel accommodation is reimbursed up to £180 per night in London and £130 per night elsewhere in the United Kingdom.

3.3 Pension and Benefits

Northwind contributes 8 percent of gross salary into the company pension scheme, matching employee contributions of up to 5 percent. Additional benefits include private medical insurance through Bupa, life assurance at four times annual salary, and a £500 annual learning and development budget for courses, conferences, or professional certifications relevant to the employee's role.

4. Information Security

4.1 Acceptable Use

Company devices are intended for business use. Limited personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with work duties, consume excessive bandwidth, or expose the company to legal or reputational risk. The installation of unauthorised software is prohibited; all software requests must be submitted to the IT team via the ServiceDesk portal.

4.2 Data Classification

Northwind classifies information into four categories: Public, Internal, Confidential, and Restricted. Restricted data, which includes customer personal data, financial records, and authentication credentials, must only be accessed from company-managed devices and may not be copied to personal storage or transmitted via personal email accounts. All Restricted data at rest must be encrypted using AES-256, and all transmission must occur over TLS 1.3.

4.3 Incident Reporting

Suspected security incidents, including phishing attempts, lost devices, and unauthorised access, must be reported to the Security team within one hour of discovery via the dedicated incident hotline at extension 4747 or by email to security@northwind-analytics.example. The Security team will triage the report within 30 minutes and initiate the relevant response procedure. False or accidental reports do not result in any disciplinary action; the company prioritises early reporting over certainty.

5. Performance and Development

5.1 Performance Reviews

Performance reviews are conducted twice annually, in June and December. Each review includes self-assessment, manager assessment, and peer feedback collected via the Lattice platform. Reviews produce one of five ratings: Below Expectations, Meeting Some Expectations, Meeting Expectations, Exceeding Expectations, and Outstanding. Employees rated Below Expectations enter a structured Performance Improvement Plan with defined milestones over a 90-day period.

5.2 Career Progression

The career framework defines six levels for individual contributors and four levels for managers, with explicit competency criteria for each. Promotion is granted when an employee has demonstrated sustained performance at the next level for at least two consecutive review cycles, supported by manager nomination and a calibration meeting with the department leadership team.

5.3 Learning Budget

As noted in section 3.3, employees receive an annual learning and development budget of £500. The budget may be applied to online courses, books, conference tickets, or certification fees. Conference travel is funded separately through the expense process described in section 3.2 where attendance is approved by the line manager. Unused learning budget does not roll over between calendar years.

6. Code of Conduct

6.1 Equal Opportunity

Northwind is committed to providing equal opportunity in employment regardless of race, religion, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, age, or any other protected characteristic under the Equality Act 2010. Discrimination, harassment, and bullying are not tolerated. Reports may be made to any line manager, the People team, or anonymously through the Speak Up portal.

6.2 Conflicts of Interest

Employees must declare any potential conflict of interest, including financial interests in suppliers, customers, or competitors, and personal relationships with individuals at organisations Northwind transacts with. Declarations are submitted annually and updated when circumstances change. Failure to declare a material conflict is treated as a serious disciplinary matter.

7. Quick Reference

The following table summarises key thresholds and limits referenced throughout this handbook.

Item	Value
Standard working week	37.5 hours
Core hours	10:00 - 16:00 GMT
Minimum office days per week	2
Annual leave entitlement	28 days (incl. public holidays)
Maximum carried leave	5 days
Paid sick days (no certification)	10 days
Home office allowance	£350
Pension match	8% (matching up to 5%)
Annual learning budget	£500
Mileage rate	45p per mile
London hotel cap	£180 per night
Security incident reporting window	1 hour